MADHYA PRADESH

MOHAN YADAV'S BIG GREEN PUSH

By Rahul Noronha

On March 13, the Madhya Pradesh State Wildlife Advisory Board approved the creation of a 614 sq. km Omkareshwar sanctuary spread across Dewas and Khandwa districts—marking the state's first major Protected Area (PA) expansion in nearly 45 years. Unlike his predecessors, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav has actively pursued conservation, previously announcing two new tiger reserves, Ratapani and Madhav, with at least three more sanctuaries besides crucial wildlife corridors in the pipeline.

Madhya Pradesh currently leads the country with nine tiger reserves, and also has 25 wildlife sanctuaries and 11 national parks covering 11,200 sq. km, or 12 per cent of the state's forest area. However, most of these were established in the 1980s, largely driven by then prime minister Indira Gandhi's conservation focus. Since then, PA expansion has slowed, with only small additions in recent decades.

In 2019, the then state forest minister, Umang Singhar of the Congress, proposed 10 new sanctuaries spanning 15,000 sq. km to bolster tiger corridors, but faced resistance even from his own party legislators. The opposition stemmed from concerns that PA designations restrict land sales, alter land-use rights and limit access to forest resources under the Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972. "The moment communities oppose the creation of a PA, politicians also join in. It is incumbent on the forest department then to convince the community to support the creation of a sanctuary or national park by highlighting the benefits that can be derived from them," says J.S. Chauhan, former chief wildlife warden, Madhya Pradesh.

So, how has Mohan Yadav succeeded where others hesitated? The Omkareshwar sanctuary's origins date back to 1987 when the Union government mandated its creation as ecological compensation for the Sardar Sarovar and Indira Sagar dam projects. The proposal languished for decades, repeatedly stalled by political and bureaucratic hurdles. Yadav, who hails from western MP, saw the sanctuary as a catalyst for tourism and wildlife conservation in a region lacking such reserves. To make the project viable, say top sources, the administration redrew boundaries, excluding 10 villages besides 117 hectares of water bodies to safeguard fishing rights. Additional land reductions accommodated dam construction and infrastructure projects.

"Conservation and development have to move ahead simultaneously," says Yadav. "The proposed Omkareshwar sanctuary will not just be a safe habitat [for tigers] in western MP but also emerge as a tourism destination given the availability of water and heritage in the form of Omkareshwar temple." For a state with the highest tiger population in India, it's crucial that Yadav maintains this conservation momentum. ■

WILDLIFE BOON



- **Spread over 614 sq. km, Omkareshwar is to become MP's 26th wildlife sanctuary**
- **The biggest addition to the state's Protected Areas in nearly 45 years, it will give a big boost to tiger conservation efforts in western MP**
- **Located in a region rich in water resources and close to the revered Omkareshwar temple, it also has huge tourism potential, according to CM Mohan Yadav**



UPFRONT

By Jeemon Jacob

In the past few years, Malayalam cinema has been basking in the praise for its treatment of unusual subjects and themes, but even the big kahunas there probably didn't see this one coming. *Empuraan* (Overlord), a Rs 180 crore 'mega action thriller' that released on March 27, has kicked off so much political controversy that less than a week after release, the creators themselves 'offered' to make cuts to smooth things out.

It all started with a superheated online campaign by the right-wing voices who were livid over the movie portraying the ruling BJP government as being responsible for the 2002 Gujarat riots. RSS mouthpiece *Organiser* singled out the film's actor-director-producer Prithviraj for their attack, saying he was the 'voice of the anti-nationals' and labelled the film 'anti-Bharat and anti-Hindu'. Other minor players like Major Ravi, a BJP state vice-president and filmmaker who claimed the Indian Army was upset with the film, predicted that superstar Mohanlal, who plays the lead role, would offer an apology as he was "unaware of the divisive content of the film".

Right on cue, Mohanlal offered an unconditional apology in an FB post the next day (March 30), saying he sincerely "regretted the mental pain caused to my loved ones...and with the realisation that the responsibility lies with all of us who worked behind